

PHILIPPE MAUCOTEL A MAN OF MANY WORDS & LETTERS

By R. B. Stuart

If you're driving down Duck Pond Road in Cutchogue, don't be surprised if you see the words NO STRESS PASSING etched in metal on the driveway gate.

If you look further you'll see about a dozen strategically placed white, three foot high S's in the backyard. These unusual works are by a Frenchman, Philippe Maucotel, an internationally known sculptor who has plied his craft since 1963. He not only has had solo shows in New York and Connecticut, but Switzerland, Bulgaria, and all over France. He's been reviewed by The New York Times, Greenwich Times, and Polish Daily News, and in Venice and Paris.

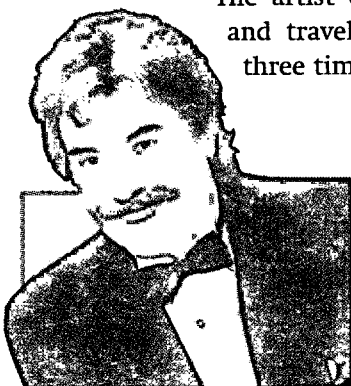
A French literature and language teacher, Maucotel converted his love for words into a more tangible form: concrete stone or metal sculptures. In 1972 he bought a brownstone in Brooklyn and needed an art collection to fill it, but couldn't afford one. So he began making one himself by writing poetry and cutting the words out — thus, thrusting him at the age of 39 into sculpting.

Maucotel moved to the United States in 1963 and taught at Brooklyn College, Community College of New York, and several other schools. He became a U.S. citizen after marrying an American who has since died; ~~they had four daughters together.~~

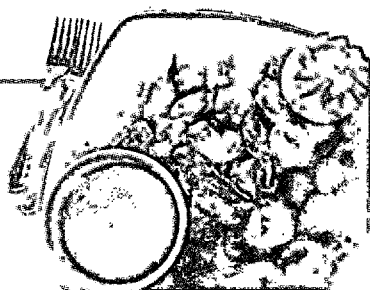
Maucotel, in search of a studio, asked a friend, Philippe Pavia of Southold (now deceased) to help out. Pavia, by chance, was selling a studio. Maucotel bought it and moved to the North Fork. He has since bought a house in Cutchogue where he currently resides.

Never A Native Tongue

The artist often visits Manhattan and travels to shows in Europe three times a year. He describes



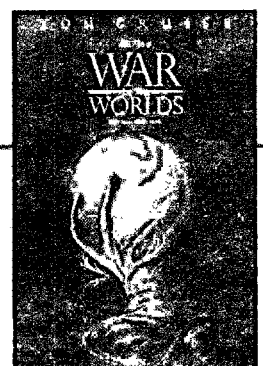
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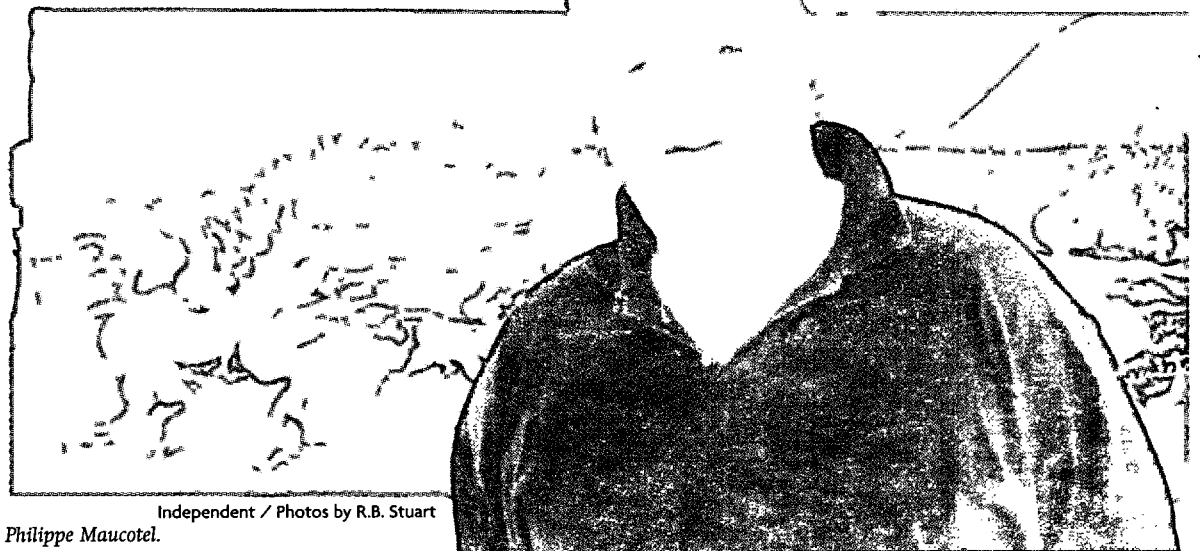
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Independent / Photos by R.B. Stuart
Philippe Maucotel.

himself as a sub-sculptor, bringing meaning below the surface.

Maucotel never went to art school. "I only went to beauty school," he said with a belt of laughter. "My role models were people that were trying to cut it in life."

His play on puns and double entendres is what drives his work, along with his fascination with language and interest in literature and poetry.

"When you're a foreigner and first move to

Speaking to the sculptures at his home, Maucotel elaborated. "The letter S inspires me because of that and because it's a sexy letter. It's a very pregnant letter," he said.

Attractive Language

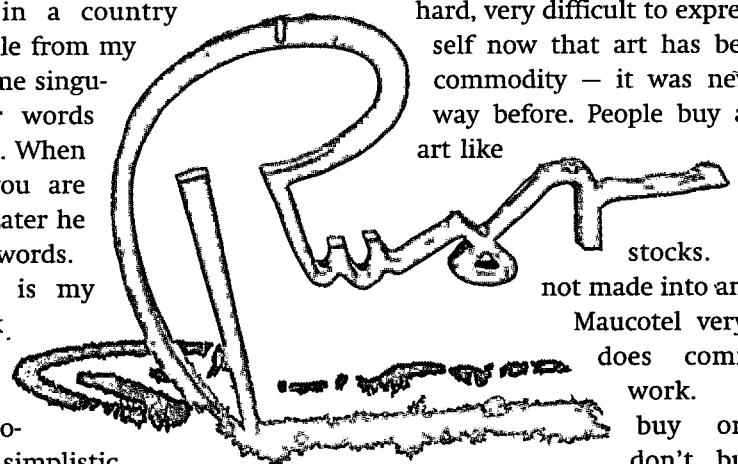
"I was very attracted to the English language. It is very sensual, very free. It's easier to be creative in English... you can manipulate the language better, rather than French which is restrictive, restrictive, and grammatically correct," he said of creating art in English rather than French. "There is a huge amount of words and slang in English. A wealth of vocabulary." His favorite artists are Marcel Duchamp, Matisse, and the post-1954 American artists, whether conceptualist, abstract, or expressionist.

He has no words of wisdom for the next generation of artists. "You're at a stage where anything goes — there is no advice, just be honest. A real artist cannot imitate anybody. It's very

hard, very difficult to express yourself now that art has become a commodity — it was never this way before. People buy and sell art like

stocks. You're not made into an artist."

Maucotel very rarely does commission work. "People buy or they don't buy. You have to be inspired."



Pun on Rust, a sculpture by Philippe Maucotel.

"Living in a country which is not my own, I was in exile from my natural language. The words become singular and strange. You rediscover words when you speak another language. When you speak many languages — you are never a native to the language." Later he discovered other artists who used words. "My symptom and amusement is my muse," he said. "I can only work when the idea amuses me. It's supposed to be funny. I have somewhat succeeded if I make people laugh — even if it is stupid and simplistic [his art]. If I can get laughter or a smile, and people are amused, then in my mind it's successful. Although, you have to read to 'get' the work, the meaning below the surface of words."